

Ask A Manager

Salary Survey Analysis

28,000+ Responses | 2021 | Multi-Country

Source: docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1IPS5dBSGtwYVbjsfbaMCYIWnOuRmJcbequohNxCyGVw

28,221

Total Responses

40+

Countries

~25,000

After Cleaning

6

Currencies Normalised

About This Report

This report analyses the Ask A Manager Salary Survey 2021 -- a crowdsourced dataset of 28,000+ self-reported salaries from professionals across industries, countries, and backgrounds. The data was cleaned, standardised, and analysed to answer five key questions about how industry, experience, location, gender, race, and education affect earnings.

Questions Answered

- Q1.** Which industry pays the most?
- Q2.** How does salary increase with years of experience?
- Q3.** How do salaries compare for the same role in different countries?
- Q4.** How much do salaries differ by gender and experience?
- Q5.** How do race and education level correlate with salary?

Key Insight

- Tech & Trade Association top the pay chart -- Trade Assoc. averages \$124,000 USD.
- Salary nearly doubles from entry level (\$57,901) to peak experience (\$100,528).
- Australia pays more than the US for most roles -- avg \$124,288 vs \$89,952.
- Male salaries grow 2x with experience; female growth is significantly slower.
- A PhD adds \$10,000-\$20,000 on average, but Professional degrees often pay more.

Dataset Overview & Cleaning

The raw dataset had 28,221 rows and 18 columns covering salary, industry, job role, country, experience, education, gender, and race. Several columns were messy -- countries had 390 unique spellings (US alone had 12 variations), and experience was stored as text ranges like '5-7 years'. Here's what was done to clean it:

Country normalisation

390 unique spellings collapsed into ~40 clean country names using a manual mapping dictionary.

Experience conversion

Text brackets like '5-7 years' converted to numeric midpoints (e.g. 6.0) for analysis.

Industry & department

Free-text entries trimmed to first 3 meaningful words to reduce noise.

Currency standardisation

All salaries converted to USD using fixed exchange rates (CAD x0.72, GBP x1.34, EUR x1.10, etc).

Outlier removal

Salaries above \$1M removed first, then IQR method applied to remove statistical outliers.

Missing values

Rows with missing industry, department, country, or education were dropped. Bonus and city filled with defaults.

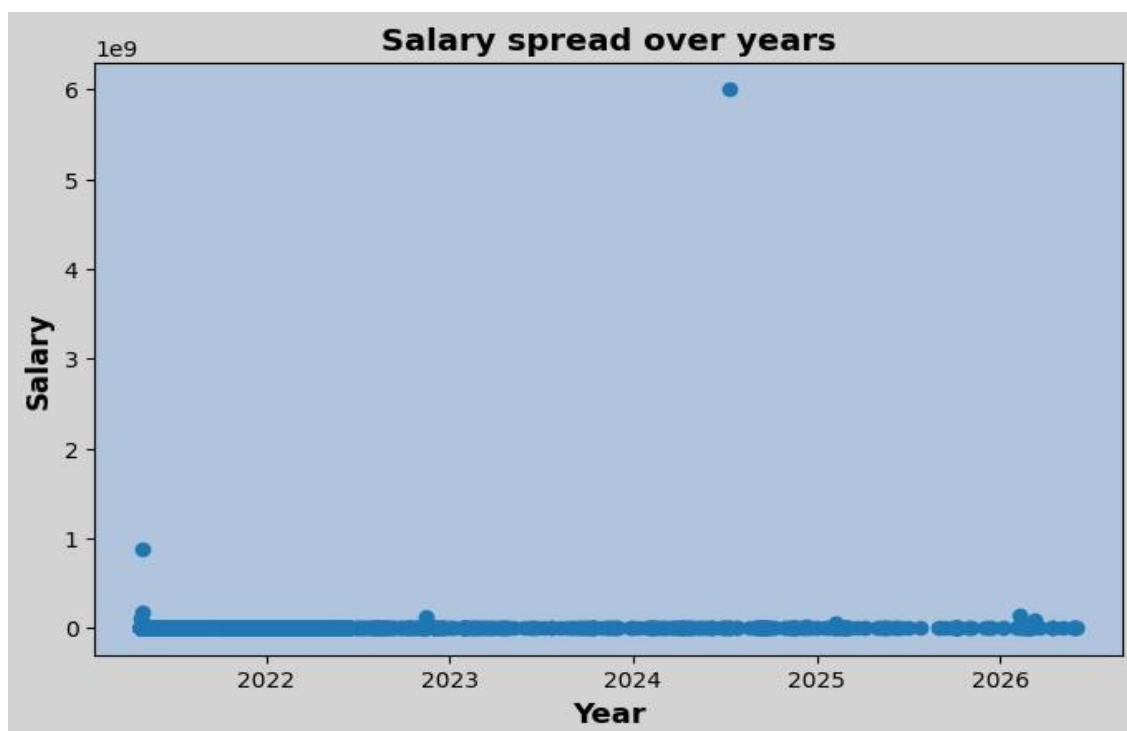
Gender & race cleanup

Verbose entries shortened to Male / Female / Non-binary / Other. Race extracted from first meaningful word.

After cleaning, ~25,000 rows remained -- sufficient for robust analysis across all five questions.

Salary Spread - Before Cleaning

The scatter below shows the raw salary spread before outlier removal. Extreme values above \$1M distort the picture -- these were removed before any analysis. *Fig 1. Raw salary scatter before outlier removal -- extreme values visible*



Q1. Which industry pays the most?

All salaries were converted to USD for a fair comparison. Industries with fewer than 6 responses were excluded to avoid skewed averages. The chart below shows the top 10 highest-paying industries by average salary.

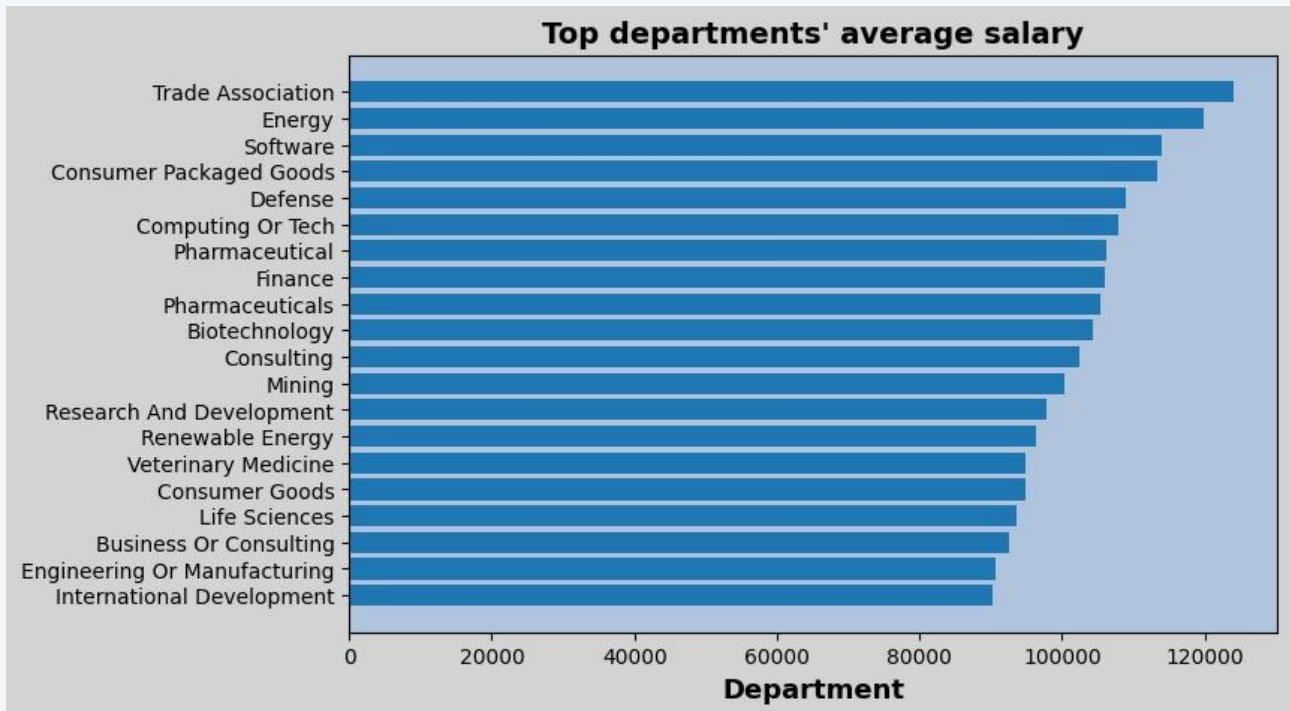


Fig 2. Top industries by average USD salary -- Trade Association leads at \$124,000.

Key Insight

- Trade Association is #1 at \$124,000 avg -- though it has few respondents.
- Energy (\$119,927), Software (\$113,950), and Consumer Packaged Goods (\$113,286) follow.
- Computing/Tech averages \$107,821 -- the most represented high-paying field.
- Finance, Pharma, and Biotech all cluster between \$104,000 - \$106,000.
- Non-profits and Education (not shown) sit significantly lower, typically under \$70,000.

The distribution below shows how salaries cluster within industries after outlier removal. Most responses sit in the \$40,000 - \$120,000 range.

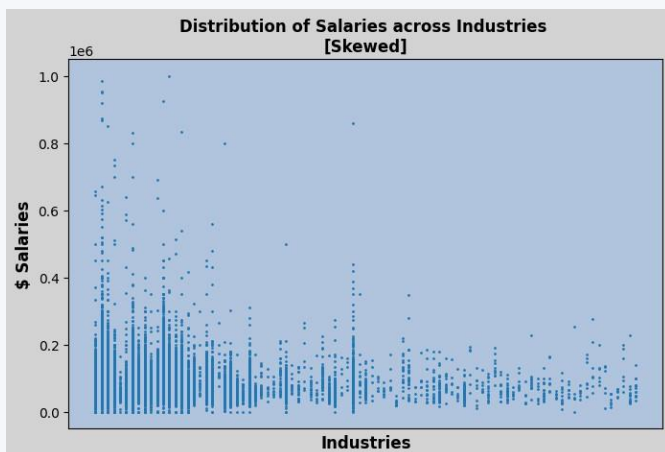


Fig 3. Salary distribution across industries.

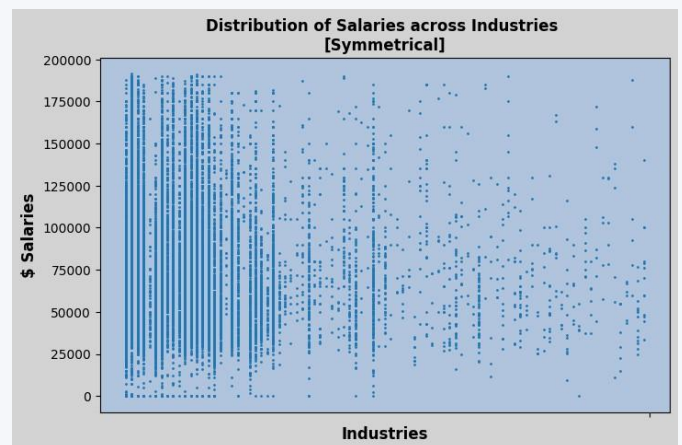


Fig 4. Post-IQR cleaned distribution.

Q2. How does salary increase with years of experience?

Experience was grouped into brackets (1, 3, 6, 9, 15.5, 25.5, 35.5, 41 years) by taking the midpoint of each range. Average USD salary was calculated per bracket.



Fig 5. Average salary by years of experience -- steady climb with a peak around 25 years.

Key Insight

- Entry level (1 yr): \$57,901 avg. Senior (25.5 yrs): \$100,528 avg -- a 74% increase.
- The biggest jump happens between 1-6 years: salary grows by ~\$20,000.
- Growth slows after 25 years -- the curve flattens, suggesting a salary ceiling.
- Even 35+ year veterans (\$97,454) earn slightly less than the 25-year peak.

Q3. How do salaries compare for the same role in different countries?

Top 10 countries and top 10 departments by response count were selected. Average USD salaries were compared department-by-department across countries.

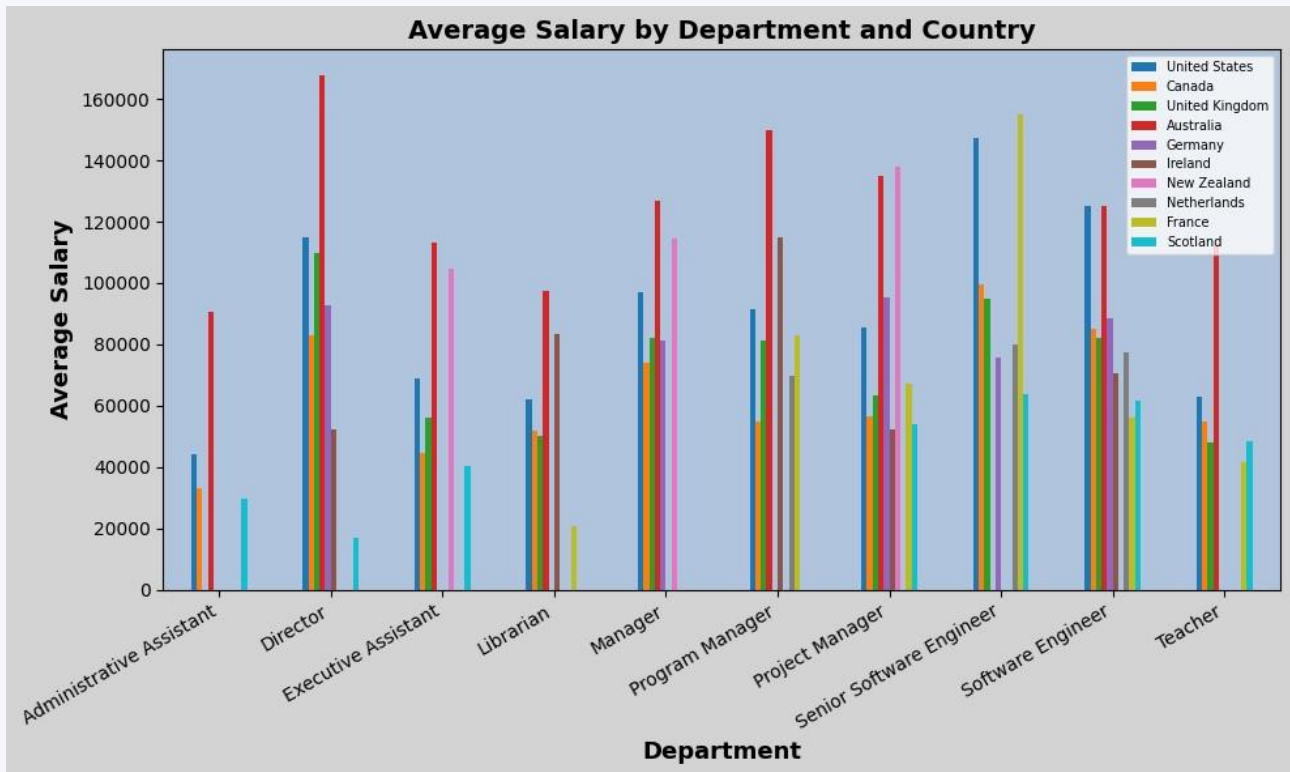


Fig 6. Average salary by department and country -- Australia stands out at the top.

Key Insight

- Australia leads overall with avg \$124,288 -- higher than the US (\$89,952) for most roles.
- New Zealand ranks 2nd at \$118,983, well above UK (\$74,120) and Canada (\$63,697).
- Australia pays the most in 7 of the top 10 departments including Director and Executive roles.
- Scotland ranks last among the top 10 countries at \$44,867 avg.
- The US ranks 3rd overall -- high pay but not the highest once other countries are normalised.

Q4. How much do salaries differ by gender and experience?

Average USD salary was calculated for each gender group across experience brackets. This reveals not just the pay gap, but how it changes as careers progress.



Fig 7. Salary by gender and experience -- the gap widens sharply after 3 years.

Key Insight

- At entry level (1 yr), the gender gap is small -- all groups earn \$50,000-\$65,000.
- By mid-career (15+ yrs), Male salaries surge ahead while Female growth is moderate.
- Male salaries nearly double from entry to peak; Female salaries grow by ~50%.
- Non-binary salaries track close to female, with high variance at senior levels.
- The gap is not just present -- it compounds. Every year of experience widens it further.

Q5. How do race and education correlate with salary?

Average salaries were broken down by race and education level simultaneously. The grouped bar chart and heatmap below show how these two factors interact.

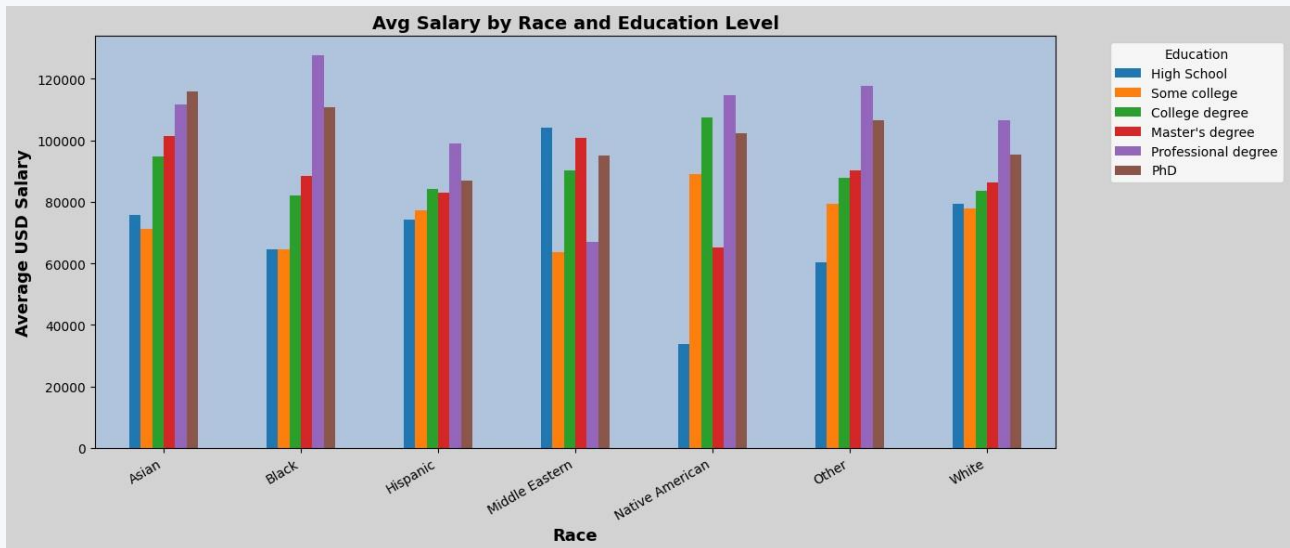


Fig 8. Average salary by race and education level -- education lifts all groups.

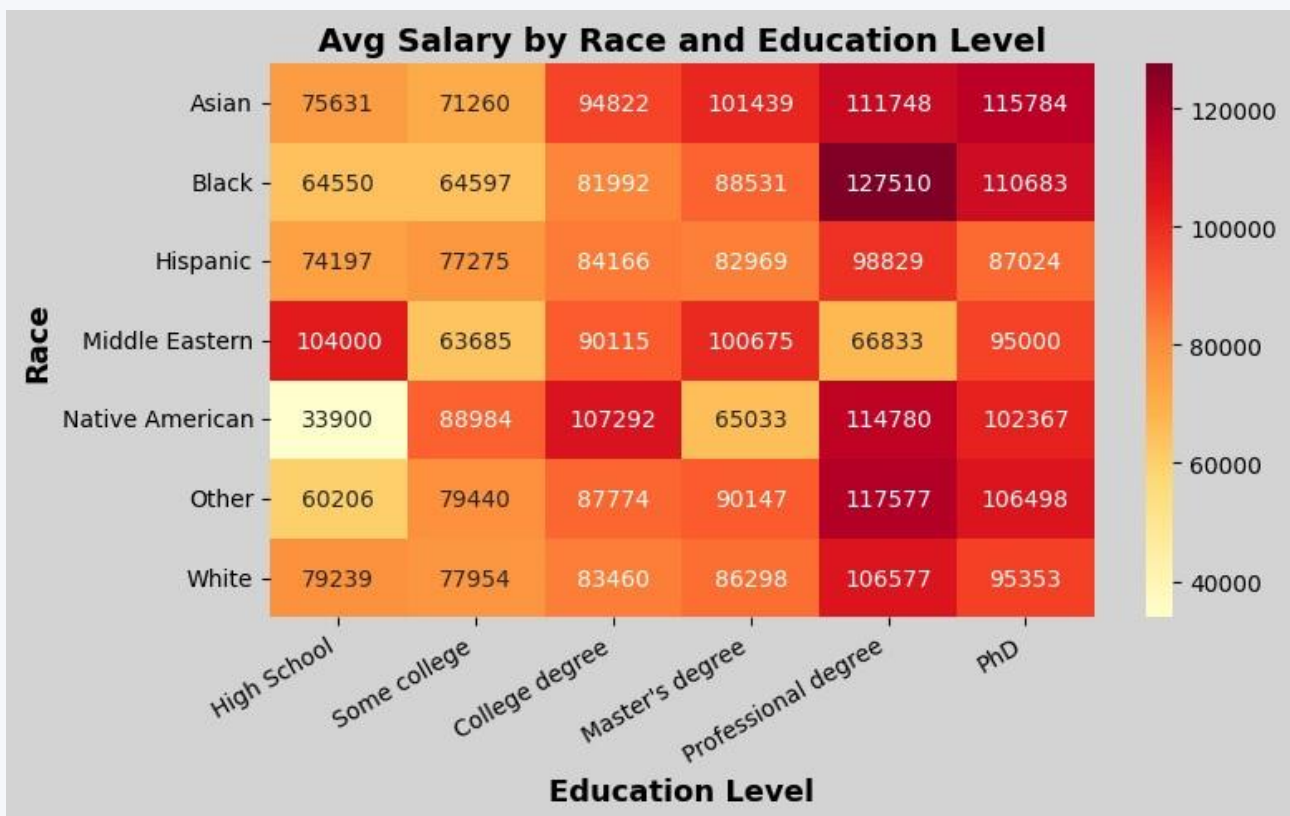


Fig 9. Heatmap view -- darker = higher salary. PhD and Professional degrees dominate.

Key Insight

- Education is the single strongest salary predictor -- a PhD or Professional degree adds \$10,000-\$20,000.
- Professional degree (MD, JD) often outearns PhD -- especially for White and Asian respondents.
- Asian respondents with advanced degrees reach the highest salary ranges in the dataset.
- Black and Hispanic respondents with the same education earn less on average than White peers.
- High School education shows the starkest racial pay gap -- the floor is lower and wider.

Summary of Findings

Across 28,000+ salary reports from professionals worldwide, five clear patterns emerge:

Industry matters most at the top

Trade Association, Energy, and Software/Tech pay 50-80% more than non-profits or education. Choosing a high-paying industry early has a compounding effect over a career.

Experience has a ceiling

Salary grows steadily until ~25 years of experience, then plateaus. The first 10 years are where growth is fastest -- a 74% salary lift from entry to peak.

Location distorts everything

Australia pays more than the US for most roles after currency normalisation. Raw salary numbers mean nothing without adjusting for country -- a \$70K salary in the UK is not the same as \$70K in the US.

The gender gap is a compounding problem

At 1 year of experience, all genders earn similarly. By 15+ years, the gap is massive. It is not just a gap -- it is a trajectory difference that grows every year.

Education helps, but unequally

Advanced degrees raise salaries across all groups, but not by the same amount. Race interacts with education in a way that means two people with the same PhD are not starting from the same place.

Data Citation

Ask A Manager Salary Survey 2021 (Responses). Published via Google Sheets.

URL: <https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1IPS5dBSGtwYVbjsfbaMCYIWnOuRmJcbequohNxCyGVw>

Accessed: 2025. Data is self-reported and represents survey respondents only -- not a statistically representative sample of the global workforce.

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